Map the intake bottleneck before automating it

Selected workflow: business analyst support-email intake, from arrival to accepted ownership.

What changed

A recent launch increased support-email volume. The analyst still has to interpret each message before the right team can act.

01 Launch pressure

More new requests and follow-ups land in the same inbox.

→

02 Manual triage

Read, classify, prioritize, choose owner, draft next step.

→

03 Accepted ownership

Handoff counts only when the correct team accepts it.

→

04 Technical action

Investigation starts after usable context reaches the owner.

Scope boundary

Start: inbound email
End: reply sent or accepted owner
Outside this scope: technical resolution

What this section produces

- Current-state map
- Handoff map
- Baseline metrics
- Capture plan

Reader takeaway: the baseline should reveal where the delay is actually coming from before solution design begins.

Current-state workflow: separate work from waiting

The analyst is not just forwarding email. They translate an unstructured request into a usable handoff.

ACTIVE WORK | WAIT / QUEUE | TEAM ACCEPTANCE

Email arrives — New request or follow-up → **Read + recover context** — Source email and prior thread → **Classify + set priority** — Type, impact, deadline → **Choose owner** — Team and next action → **Draft handoff / reply** — Context and proposed response → **Review / accept** — Correct team confirms ownership

Support / requester | Business analyst owns interpretation | Receiving team owns next action

Clarification loop
If context is missing, the request returns to the analyst or requester before any real work starts.

Reassignment loop
If the owner is wrong, the team forwards it again and the intake clock keeps running.

Resolution starts later
Technical resolution is outside this section, but the handoff quality affects when it begins.

Baseline focus: measure the queue, the analyst effort, and the time until the correct team accepts ownership.

Request family tells you what evidence the next team needs

A label alone is not a handoff. The receiving team needs enough context to act without coming back for basics.

01 Setup / implementation

Likely owner

Service or implementation owner

Handoff needs

service, launch milestone, blocker, requested action

02 Invoices / contracts / sales

Likely owner

Operations or commercial owner

Handoff needs

reference, document, party, actual question

03 Technical issue / feature request

Likely owner

Support or product owner

Handoff needs

defect vs request, evidence, impact, affected service

04 P0 / P1, privacy or safety

Likely owner

Designated escalation owner

Handoff needs

deadline, risk, affected users, immediate next step

Special case: multi-topic email

Route each actionable issue or appoint one coordinator. Do not bury a high-urgency second issue inside a routine message.

Special case: ambiguous follow-up

If the email depends on prior context, keep it with the analyst until the thread, case record or prior owner is known.

Current adaptation: request families came from the source workflow. Enterprise owners and handoff rules are confirmation items.

The analyst queue can delay the whole delivery chain

The downstream cost is not just analyst time. Technical teams receive work later, with weaker context.

More inbound work → **More triage pressure** → **Later accepted ownership** → **Less protected technical time**

Unread / untriaged queue

Request reaches the technical team late, before its own queueing begins.

Check: arrival to first touch; unowned case age.

Incomplete context

Engineers ask for service, evidence, impact or prior history before starting.

Check: clarification touches; needs-info returns.

Wrong or split owner

Teams reassign work and secondary issues can remain unowned.

Check: reassignment count; accepted owner.

Urgency not explicit

A time-sensitive issue arrives without enough warning, disrupting planned work.

Check: deadline captured; priority changed at handoff.

Process principle: improve the handoff, not merely the forwarding speed.

Baseline dashboard: five measures are enough

Measure demand, human effort, handoff delay and rework before claiming improvement.

3-5 min reference

Reported time in the source workflow for reading, classification and drafting. Enterprise baseline should time routing, review and rework separately.

01

Inbound volume

Messages per business day. Split new requests from follow-ups.

Daily count; pre/post launch comparison

02

Active handling time

Minutes spent reading, classifying, routing, drafting or reworking.

Minutes/message; analyst hours/day

03

Time to correct owner

Receipt to accepted ownership by the correct team.

Median and P90; pending cases separate

04

Intake backlog

Cases not replied to or accepted by daily cutoff.

Open count and oldest case age

05

Handoff rework

Cases returned or reassigned for missing context or wrong owner.

% returned/reassigned with reason

Do not mix elapsed time with work time. Waiting in an inbox is a different problem from slow manual review.

Measurement setup: lightweight, auditable and repeatable

Use approved records, a short time study and a shared check sheet. The goal is a defensible baseline, not a reporting project.

01

Collect demand

Gmail metadata

Message ID, thread ID, received timestamp

02

Time work

Timer + activity log

30-50 observed cases across request types

03

Trace handoff

Case ID + acknowledgement

Link handoff sent to accepted owner

04

Analyze pattern

Sheets / Excel pivots

Volume, wait time, rework and request mix

05

Validate findings

BA + receiving teams

Review examples before design decisions

Pre / post launch volume

Compare 10 matched business days where records exist. Keep timezone, scope and staffing notes consistent.

Observed case timing

Time routine, multi-topic and follow-up cases separately. Pause the timer during unrelated interruptions.

Acceptance tracking

A Slack post or ticket creation event is not enough. Count handoff completion only after ownership is accepted.

Techniques used: workflow mapping, time study, check sheet, stratification by request type and case-linked handoff tracing.

Use two logs because waiting time is not work time

The case log shows elapsed flow. The activity log shows actual human effort. Both are needed.

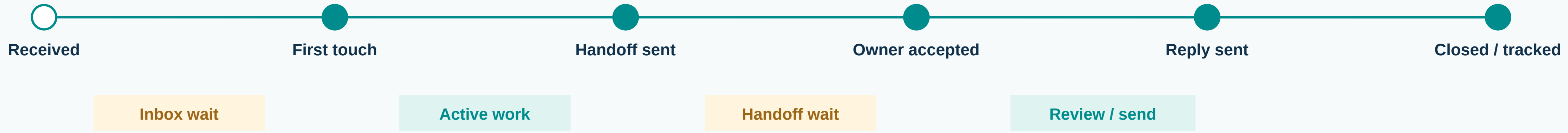
Case log / one row per request

Identity	Case ID, message/thread link
Request	Type, priority, primary owner
Events	Received, first touch, handoff sent, accepted
Outcome	Status, clarification or return reason

Activity log / one row per touch

Link	Case ID and person / role
Activity	Read, classify, route, draft or clarify
Timing	Start, stop and paused minutes
Rework	Flag and reason for repeat handling

How the timing is read



Key distinction: email timestamps prove when a case moved, but not how long a person worked on it.

Use the baseline to decide what to improve first

The baseline should point to the highest-leverage intervention instead of assuming automation solves everything.

If the unread queue is the main wait

Improve intake coverage and triage routing. Check BA capacity before adding automation.

If reading and drafting dominate effort

Use AI-assisted classification and draft generation, with human review.

If requests return for missing context

Improve required inputs, summaries and ownership rules before routing faster.

If correctly owned cases still wait

Review technical-team capacity and queue priorities. Intake automation alone will not fix this.

Baseline handoff package

- Current-state map
- Request / owner map
- Timed case log
- Metric definitions
- Evidence gaps

Evidence boundary: this section defines what should be measured. It does not claim measured improvement or post-launch volume without data.